had to judge their self-worth. In the process, the modernity/rationality complex was entrenched in every colonised society and reinforced in the colonising society as well.[9] The direct and intended consequence of coloniality and the introduction of the modernity/rationality complex was the creation of supposedly universal standards for morals, ethics, religion, language, knowledge, scientific temper, political organisation, nationhood, individual rights and more—in short, culture and civilisation.[10]

This complex did not die with decolonisation but remains alive and kicking even today, just as coloniality is. After all, as scholars have identified, coloniality goes hand in hand with modernity/rationality and vice versa. As long as coloniality is alive, despite its outward proclamations of open-mindedness, dialogue and diversity, the colonial DNA of modernity and rationality will continue to actively resist and oust indigeneity. It will staunchly refuse to accord indigeneity the respect of an equal and will continue to use time and ‘reason’ as weapons to question the very relevance of the indigenous point of view, because the underlying premise—indigeneity is racially inferior—has not changed. The successful universalisation of the modernity/rationality complex is further evidenced by the fact that neither word is prefaced with ‘European’ anymore despite the entire edifice being Eurocentric.

Interestingly, in her paper titled ‘Early Modernity: The History of a Word’, Patricia Seed, who specialises in early modern and colonial European eras, traced the origins of the word ‘modern’ to the sixth century ce, when it was first used in northern Italy.[11] This was when the Roman Empire still existed but northern Italy was conquered and ruled by Germanic Ostrogoths. According to Seed, the word ‘modern’ made its debut in the context of architecture when the Ostrogothic ruler of northern Italy encouraged wealthy Roman families to undertake reconstruction of public buildings at their private expense. The outcome was that the new buildings had a different architectural style that distinguished them from those built under Roman imperial rule. Praising the contribution of one particular family for its reconstruction of the Theatre of Pompey, the scribe of the Ostrogothic ruler called the family ‘a careful imitator of antiquity and the noblest founder of modern works’ (translation). In this context, according to Seed, the word modern simply meant ‘different’ without any value being imputed to it, neither positive nor negative.